

ALBERT LANDRY GALLERY

111 EAST 79th STREET, NEW YORK CITY, N.Y.

JANUARY 7-26 1963

OPENING JANUARY 7, 4 TO 7 P.M.

maurice

SIEVAN

paintings

*Photo by
Lee Sievan*



MAURICE SIEVAN *by Kenneth B. Sawyer*

Since about 1945, the United States has manifested a rousing nascence of painting and sculpture. I say "Nascence" and not renascence since prior to the post-war years there was little that could be called an indigenous New World art--that is, an art immediately recognizable as stemming from the unique socio-political phenomenon that is America. To be sure, we have had our champions. One need only recall West and Copley, Blakelock and Ryder, Homer and Eakins, Elshemius and Bellows. And there were those, most notably Catlin and Remington, who limned scenes uniquely American, and those, particularly the "Ash Can School", who attacked the problem of discovering beauty in American urban situations. We have had our modernists, as well: Marin, Dove, Davis, Stella, and a few others who risked ridicule and

economic calamity to create an art that was as fresh and vigorous as the nation itself.

But in the main these men, whatever their gifts, were fundamentally European artists who continued, and sometimes augmented, the European easel tradition. The first four decades of the twentieth century witnessed no art to challenge the supremacy of France; indeed, no American could aspire to stellar magnitude without at least some acknowledgement from Paris. World War II changed all that. Isolation from the flow of ideas from the Continent proved not only salutary, but crucial to those lively young Americans still finding their way. Maurice Sievan was among the vanguard who rose to the challenge and who emerged as painters unequivocally American in achievement.

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Sievan's evolution was, like that of his contemporaries, gradual-- based on the solid foundations of technique and the awareness of what had gone before. But where others depended on impact, on the frontal assault, Sievan chose the ways of indirection. While his oils are certainly dramatic, they are subtle and poetic as well. When he returned to the human figure nearly ten years ago he returned to it with the vocabulary of Abstract Expressionism already assimilated. The result has been something more than fortuitous. His earlier figures, nebulous, scarcely defined, were nonetheless unmistakably feminine, sensual and mysterious. They appeared alone, in twos, and in groupings like suppliants in grave Saturnian rites. More recently, they have grown clearer to the eye. Still more adumbrated than defined, they emerge from the

density of their element, command the eye with their sinuous line, then return to that primal source from which they came.

Sievan's art is sombre; there is a Plutonian murk to his palette, even, curiously, when he illumines a surface with a primary. Perhaps the secret is in his textures. They are thinly painted and meticulously controlled, but they erect an illusory density, a barrier to the eye. Penetrating this barrier, and mingling with it are the forms of his figures, at once solid and mysterious, nebulous and grand. In this, his second exhibition at the Albert Landry Gallery, Maurice Sievan proves once for all that he has consolidated the gains of his estimable past and is in process of driving them, like Yeats' Hanrahan, unquiet through the dawn. His is an art of the future, which, to our astonishment, has already occurred.

New York, October 1962